percent more than the average rate of growth during the seventies.

Adversity made us tougher. New competition made us work harder.

Again, I don’t take credit for this. The American people did it. And it wasn’t only factory workers and plant managers who brought America back. A lot of our growth during the eighties didn’t come from the giants of American industry but from smaller, innovative companies that tapped new markets, often with new products born out of their own ingenuity. Most of those millions of new jobs produced during the economic expansion were created by entrepreneurs—independent businesspeople pursuing one of the oldest of American dreams.

I met a lot of them while I was president, and if ever there was evidence of why Communism failed and capitalism triumphed, it was in the faces of these people. They were the people capitalism was all about. I heard story after story of someone taking an idea to the bank, borrowing, working hard, then experiencing the joy of seeing a business flourish. They were just ordinary Americans who had had an idea or a dream or a longing for economic independence, and they had gone after it. They had taken risks, worked, and realized their goal. Not all of them succeeded, but America gave every one of them the opportunity to fulfill their dream.

One woman I met had graduated from college with plans to become a classical pianist. Then she had developed arthritis in her hands and couldn’t play anymore. So, there she was, wondering what she would do with her life. One of her aunts said, “You’ve always made wonderful brownies, why don’t you make some and sell them down at the neighborhood grocery store? At least you’ll have some spending money until you find out what you’re going to do.” Well, she started doing that and before long she was selling